

Introduction to American Studies

AMST-101

Spring 2024

Monday & Thursday, 9:55-11:10

Pendleton East 327

Instructor: Ian Alexander (he/him)

Office Hours: Monday, 1:00-2:30pm, Wednesday, 12:30-2:25

Pendleton East 21X

By Appointment! IRL or Zoom.

Please come by!

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Course Description:

An interdisciplinary examination of some of the varieties of American experience, aimed at developing a functional vocabulary for further work in American Studies or related fields. Along a brief review of American history, the course will direct its focus on important moments in that history, including the present, investigating each of them in relation to selected cultural, historical, artistic, and political events, figures, institutions, and texts. Course topics include intersectional ethnic and gender studies, consumption and popular culture, urban and suburban life, racial formation, and contemporary American culture.

Assignments:

- **Mythology (20%, due Friday, February 9th)**
 - **In pairs:** Identify an American myth, and tear it apart in a video or audio project, 7-10 minutes. Final product should do the following:
 - Identify myth. How does it go?
 - What is factually untrue about it?
 - Why is it important for US national identity and mythology more broadly? How does it fit into the dominant story about the US?
 - Why is the truth of the matter important, beyond *just knowing* and beyond *uncovering silenced past* etc – what is its bearing on the present?
 - Who is impacted by this mythology and how?
 - Try to find a myth that we might not all know much about. All groups must get approval from me for their topic. I can help you find one if you are truly stumped.

- **Write About A Song (Or An Album) (10%, due Friday, March 8th)**
 - **Solo.** Pick a song that a) you like and b) speaks to one of the readings in the class. Write a 500-word (one-page single-spaced or two double-spaced) piece about how your song connects to this reading, and its main concepts and argument. This could focus on lyrics, but it could also take the rest of the song's construction and performance into consideration. You could choose an older song that literally and consciously reflected on a moment in US history that the reading talks about – or you could make a bigger reach and draw a less obvious connection. Writing can be quite personal for this assignment. Song absolutely does not need to be “American.” Cite the material appropriately.
 - **This will be public to the class, and turned into a shared folder**
- **Place-Based Reflection (10%, due Friday April 5th)**
 - **Solo.** Pick one reading that resonated with you. Think about the heart of the argument, the most important ideas in that reading. Now, write a 750-word (3 pages double-spaced) piece about a place you know you well – it could be home, somewhere you visited, somewhere you have passed through. But you need to have been there. How does this reading, and its core idea, help you think a little differently about that place? Or what has it helped you better understand about that place? Personal essay style – whatever that means to you – *not* formal academic writing here. But you still must cite.
 - **Can be shared, or turned in only to me.**
- **Lead Discussion (15%, mixed date)**
 - **In groups of 3**, prepare to lead the group in discussion. This can be done either standing or seated – but no slide shows. This is not a summary of the text or a report on the author... Rather, this is about:
 - Reading closely. Reading more carefully than you normally might. Really getting into the week's readings.
 - Drawing out the core themes, problems, and arguments.
 - Posing thoughtful and discussion-generative questions, and guiding group discussion (can be large or small group or both!)
 - Guide us toward at least one key passage, explaining why that one stands out (beyond “it's really interesting”)
 - Students will make a handout. More detailed instructions to follow.
- **Short Presentations. (15%, mixed date)**
 - **In pairs**, prepare a 10 minute presentation answering the question on the syllabus that week. Presentations should include the following info:
 - Who is/was the person? When and where do/did they live?
 - If relevant: how did they die?

- What did they do that made them noteworthy?
 - What were their political commitments and values?
 - How do these connect with the week's readings?
- o Either prepare a very basic slideshow with some of this info, or make a google doc. Whatever you make, share it in the class drive folder the night before your presentation.
- **Mixtape(30%)**
 - o **Groups of 5.** Make a compilation of 5-10 media objects – songs, visual artwork, videos, speech clips, propaganda, poems – that come together to articulate something important about American Studies. These can serve as a kind of counter-history, a cultural history, evidence of a certain form of struggle, or evidence of a certain form of oppression, or a silenced aspect of life (history, culture, politics) in the US or “the Americas” – or even elsewhere, if it directly engages with actions by the US (imperialism).
 - **Due March 1** Collect your objects. Must include work in at least 2 different media. Provide a brief description for each, and a rationale for their assembly as a coherent, themed “mixtape.”
 - **Due April 5th** Write a short analysis for each one. How long these are will depend on how many you have chose and how much explication each needs. If you have 5 pieces, 500 words for each. If you have 10, more like 300 words for each. These probably make sense to do individually.
 - **Due April 19nd** Write an introduction to the material that makes a strong argument for their assembly – how they work together, speak to one another, relate and differ from one another. What comes out of them as a whole? This must refer to at least 3 course readings, and be about 1200-1500 words.
 - **Due April 29th** Write a conclusion that connects the whole project to some active political problem facing or created by the US, one that is not just a repetition of the intro or the materials. (For example, if you made a mix of coal mining songs, you could draw a short connection to climate justice).
 - **Due May 9th** Put it all together in a final medium. This can be a zine, or a video project.

Evaluation:

I want you to take intellectual risks in this class, without fear of receiving a lower grade as a consequence. For serious, committed and genuine work, students will receive an A. When completed assignments do not satisfy the given requirements, appear to be rushed and careless, severely misinterpret or misrepresent course readings and discussion, or look like that horse drawing meme, I will give feedback and a provisional grade. I will

then ask students to make revisions and resubmit the work for full credit, within 2 weeks. They may opt to accept the provisional grade as their final grade for that assignment. After revisions, a final grade is given, equal to or higher than provisional grade. This can be done no more than 2 times. After that, the first grade is the final grade.

That's kind of confusing, so here it is in board-game style instructions

1. Student completes and turns in an assignment on time, triggering step 2
2. Instructor reads/ watches/ listens to assignment, and decides to give either an A, or else a provisional grade. If an A is given, assignment steps are over. If a provisional grade is given, step 3 is triggered.
3. Instructor provides provisional grade (B,C,D...), with feedback to help the student improve the work. (Feedback does not equal instructions!) Student decides whether to proceed to step 4 or step 5.
4. Student accepts provisional grade. Assignment ends.
5. Student revises project and resubmits within 2 weeks of receiving the provisional grade, triggering step 6.
6. Instructor re-evaluates the work, and gives a final grade that may not be lower than original provisional grade. Assignment ends.

Accessibility:

This is the language Wellesley asks us to include:

If you have a disability or condition, either long-term or temporary, and need reasonable academic adjustments in this course, please contact Accessibility and Disability Resources (ADR) to get a letter outlining your accommodation needs, and submit that letter to me. You should request accommodations as early as possible in the semester, or before the semester begins, since some situations can require significant time for review and accommodation design.

If you need immediate accommodations, please arrange to meet with me as soon as possible. If you are unsure but suspect you may have an undocumented need for accommodations you are encouraged to contact ADR. They can provide assistance including screening and referral for assessments.

Disability Services can be reached at accessibility@wellesley.edu , at 781-283-2434, by scheduling an appointment online at their website, <https://www.wellesley.edu/adr> or by visiting their offices on the 3rd floor of Clapp Library, rooms 316 and 315.

Please communicate with me about what you need to feel supported and comfortable in class. I will do everything I can to help all students participate and enjoy this class without feeling overwhelmed or pressured into exhaustion. Sometimes I need some help identifying what that can be.

Attendance and Participation are required for sustained discussion, which is the most important aspects of this class. I expect you to show up almost every session and to engage with readings, your fellow students, and me. But of course sometimes you have to miss class.

I ask that you communicate clearly and actively with me when you are unable to show up, when you feel overwhelmed, or when you have fallen behind. I can help you get caught up! However, this does not mean summarizing class sessions after absences – when you miss class, it's on you to contact a fellow student to ask what you missed.

I also ask that if you are feeling unwell, stay home for your own wellbeing. If you are feeling unwell due to a contagious illness, please stay home for our wellbeing.

In cases where students are missing a lot of class, or they are coming to the classroom but appear to be checked out (which is also a case of not showing up), I will send an email at the halfway point of the semester, OR when it becomes an issue (for example, if someone misses 2 or 3 consecutive sessions without letting me know what's going on). Students who hear nothing from me are participating and showing up adequately. **Students who do hear from me about inadequate attendance/participation will have their overall course grade dropped a full letter, unless they show improvement through the remainder of the semester.**

What is adequate participation? We will define this as a group in the first week of class.

Technology:

- Students may use computers and tablets in class, for the following purposes:
 - Notetaking
 - Bringing digital copies of course readings
 - Collaborative document exercises
 - The occasional google search for reference
- Please do not use them for social media, amazon dot com, or video streaming.
- Please, please, please don't have your phones out in class. Billions of dollars have been spent researching how to make smartphones the most powerfully distracting force in the known universe...not only for the user but for everyone else in the room. **If you need to use a cell phone, even if it's for an important text or email, just step out of the classroom.**

Communication:

- For content questions about readings etc, please hold your questions for class discussion or come see me in office hours.
- If you have an assignment or logistical question, please be sure it is not answered on this syllabus before emailing.
- I will do my best to respond to all email within 48 hours during the week. Often it will be faster. If it's been longer than 48 hours, you can send me a reminding nudge.
- If it helps you, I encourage you to set up some kind of communication network among yourselves for sharing notes or getting caught up after an absence. You should have at

least one person you can text or email to say “Hey I missed class Monday, do you have any notes?” That person should not be me.

Readings:

- Readings will be made available through Google and direct links where possible. Otherwise, I will work with the library to put some texts on reserve. You won’t have to buy books for this class.
- *Most of these are available through a simple search, so if something is not available in the folder, it is still on you to look for it.*
- Some of these readings contain references to state and interpersonal violence. While I will sometimes make mention of particularly rough readings, please keep this in mind when you approach texts and take them at a pace that is sustainable for you.

Reading Schedule:

- **Week 1: This (Colonized) Land**
 - Monday, January 22
 - WATCH: [“American Revolution Waged for Slavery – Professor Gerald Horne” interview by Abby Martin \(33 mins\)](#)
 - WATCH: [“Geographies of Racial Capitalism with Ruth Wilson Gilmore – An Antipode Foundation Film” \(16 mins\)](#)
 - Thursday, January 25
 - Roxanne Dunbar-Ortiz: *An Indigenous People’s History of the United States*
 - “Introduction: This Land”
 - Chapter 1: “Follow the Corn”
 - OPTIONAL: Roxanne Dunbar-Ortiz: *An Indigenous People’s History of the United States*
 - Chapter 2: “Culture of Conquest”
- **Week 2: What is Race?**
 - Monday, January 29
 - David Roediger: [“Historical Foundations of Race”](#)
 - Ida B. Wells: [“Lynching, Our National Crime” \(1909\)](#)
 - Thursday, February 1
 - Ruth Wilson Gilmore: *Abolition Geography: Essays Toward Liberation*
 - Chapter 8: “Race, Prisons, War: Scenes from the History of US Violence”

Presentation: Whose Land Is This?

- **Week 3: Colonialism & Fascism**

- Monday, February 5
 - Aime Cesaire: *Discourse on Colonialism*
 - First Half (31-53)
- Thursday, February 8
 - Aime Cesaire: *Discourse on Colonialism*
 - Second Half (54-78)
 - WATCH: [“The Haitian Revolution and Its Causes”](#) by The World History Project (12 mins)

Presentation: Who Was Toussaint Louverture?

- **Week 4: Colonial Conquest & Anti-Colonial Struggle**

- Monday, February 12
 - Nick Estes: [“‘Freedom is a Place’: Long Traditions of Anti-Colonial Resistance in Turtle Island”](#)
 - WATCH: Mali Obomsawin, [“Wawasint8da”](#) (music vid, 6 mins)
 - WATCH: [“Sioux Ghost Dance”](#) (<1 min)
 - OPTIONAL: Nick Estes & Rebecca Nagle: “Taking Children, Taking the Land”
 - [Talk on YouTube, about 90 minutes](#)
- Thursday, February 15
 - K. Kamakaoka’ilima Long: [“Hawai’i: Mauna Kea, Hawaiian Independence and the Politics of Jurisdiction”](#) (Jan 2, 2017 in *The Funambulist*)

Presentation: Who is Leonard Peltier?

- **Week 5: Enslaved Labor**

- Tuesday, February 20
 - WEB Du Bois: *Black Reconstruction in America*
 - Chapter 1: “The Black Worker”
 - WATCH: [“Uncovering the History of the Banjo with Rhiannon Giddens: From African Roots to American Music”](#)
 - WATCH: [“Why this Instrument explains Black American folk music” \(Jake Blount\)](#)
- Thursday, February 22
 - WEB Du Bois: *Black Reconstruction in America*
 - Chapter 4: “General Strike”
 - OPTIONAL: [“We Still Charge Genocide”: Jalil Muntaqim Speaks to National Black Caucus of the Teamsters Union”](#)

Presentation: Who Was Queen Mother Moore?

- **Week 6: Histories of Reproductive Violence**

- Monday, February 26
 - Angela Y. Davis: "[The Role of the Black Woman in the Community of Slaves](#)"
 - Sanjana Manjeshwar: "[America's Forgotten History of Forced Sterilization](#)" (in *Berkeley Political Review*, November 4, 2020)
- Thursday, February 29
 - Angela Davis: *Blues Legacies and Black Feminism*
 - "I Used to be Your Sweet Mama: Ideology, Sexuality, and Domesticity"
 - LISTEN: Bessie Smith, Ma Rainey, et al playlist

Presentation: Who Was Fannie Lou Hamer?

- **Week 7: Circuits of Capital**

- Monday, March 4
 - Lisa Nakamura: "Indigenous Circuits: Navajo Women and the Racialization of Early Electronic Manufacture"
 - LISTEN: Wosdee Podcast: "[Episode 32: The Fairchild Incident in 1975](#)" (22 mins)
- Thursday, March 7
 - Siddharth Kara: "[Your Smartphone Has a Human Cost](#)" (Feb 16, 2023, *In These Times*)
 - WATCH: [Maquilapolis](#) (Funari, De La Torre, 2006)

Presentation: Who Was Patrice Lumumba?

- **Week 8: Anti-Communism and Anti-Black State Terror**

- Monday, March 11
 - Charisse Burden-Stelly: *Black Scare/Red Scare: Theorizing Capitalist Racism in the United States*
 - Chapter 7, "Theorizing Anticommunism as a Mode of Governance"
 - LISTEN: Paul Robeson
 - [HUAC Hearing, June 12, 1956 \(12 mins\)](#)
 - "Joe Hill," "John Brown's Body," "No More Auction Block"
- Thursday, March 14
 - Orisanmi Burton: "Targeting Revolutionaries: The Birth of the Carceral Warfare Project, 1970-78"
 - WATCH: [The Murder of Fred Hampton](#) (1971)
 - WATCH: "[The Day the Police Dropped a Bomb on Philadelphia](#)" (*Vice*, [with Ramona Africa, 12 mins](#))
 - LISTEN: Gil Scott-Heron, *Pieces of a Man* (1971) – any three songs

Presentation: Who Was Vicki Garvin?

///SPRING BREAK!///

- **Week 9: Queer and Trans Liberation**

- Monday, March 25
 - Leslie Feinberg: *Transgender Warriors*
 - Part 4, Chapters 12, 13, 14 (“From Germany to Stonewall” & “To Be or Not To Be” & “Sisterhood: Make It Real!”)
 - WATCH: Orville Peck: “[Dead of Night](#)” (music video)
 - WATCH: Sylvester: “You Make Me Feel (Mighty Real)” (music video)
- Thursday, March 28
 - Leslie Feinberg: *Transgender Warriors*
 - Part 4, Chapter 15, “Making History”
 - “[The Queer Nation Manifesto](#)” (1990)
 - Leslie Feinberg: “Transgender Liberation” (Pamphlet)
 - WATCH: Lavender Country, “I Can’t Shake the Stranger Out of You” (music video)

Presentation: Who Was Essex Hemphill?

- **Week 10: Carceral Warfare**

- Monday, April 1
 - WATCH: *The Prison in Twelve Landscapes* (Brett Story, 2016)
 - Russell “Maroon” Shoatz
 - “Death by Regulation” (short)
 - “Message from a Death Camp” (short)
 - Bettina Aptheker: “[The Social Functions of the Prisons in the United States](#)” (1971)
- Thursday, April 4
 - Assata Shakur
 - “[Women in Prison: How We Are](#)” (8 pages)
 - WATCH: *We’re Alive!* (Gleason, Lesiak, Levitt, et al 1974)
 - Wendy Trevino
 - “From Santa Rita 128-131” (poem)

Who Was Yuri Kochiyama?

- **Week 11: US Imperialist Warfare**

- Monday, April 8
 - [Ju-Hyun Park: “Wipe Out All Life’: Postwar Liberalism and Mass Killing in Korea](#)” (*The Funambulist* August 31, 2021)

Presentation: Who Was Luisa Capetillo?

- Thursday, April 11 **NO CLASS MEETING – RUHLMAN**

- WATCH: Abby Martin & Eugene Puryear: [“A Guide to US Empire in Africa: Neocolonial Order & AFRICOM”](#)
- Chris Paterson: [“The Afghanistan-ization of Africa”](#)
- **Week 12: Palestine**
 - Monday, April 15 **NO CLASS MEETING – MARATHON DAY**
 - LISTEN: *Let’s Talk Palestine*: [“The 100 Year History of Israel-Palestine”](#) (90 mins)
 - Muhammed El-Kurd
 - “Rifqa,” poem
 - Refaat Alareer
 - [“If I Must Die.”](#) poem
 - Thursday, April 18
 - Steven Salaita: *Decolonizing Native America and Palestine*
 - Chapter 1: “How Palestine Became Important to American Indian Studies”
 - [South African “Application Instituting Proceedings” against Israel, December 2023 \(selections\)](#)

Who Is Leila Khaled?

- **Week 13: Climate Cataclysms**
 - Monday, April 22
 - LISTEN: [Working Class History: “West Virginia Mine Wars Pts 1 & 2”](#)
 - WATCH: [“Dreadful Memories: Sarah Gunning, Early Years”](#) (12 mins)
 - LISTEN: Sarah Ogan Gunning: [“I Hate the Company Bosses”](#) (song, 4 mins)
 - Thursday, April 25
 - Max Ajl: *A People’s Green New Deal*
 - Introduction
 - Chapter 1: “Green Transition – or Fortress Eco-Nationalism?”
 - LISTEN: Jake Blount, *The New Faith* (2022)
 - OPTIONAL: [“World People’s Conference on Climate Change and the Rights of Mother Earth”](#)

Who Is Red Fawn?

- **Week 14: American Studies Mixtapes**
 - Monday, April 29
 - Shellyne Rodriguez: [“Third World Mixtapes: Infrastructures of Feeling”](#) (zine, companion piece to an exhibit by the author/artist)
 - Wednesday, May 1 – **INTERNATIONAL WORKERS’ DAY!**
 - Austin McCoy: [“It’s Bigger Than Hip-Hop: The Many Educations of Rap” \(in The Baffler Jan 2024\)](#)